



Plant focus: azaleas and rhododendrons

Big and bold or small and dainty, azaleas and rhododendrons offer a great choice of blooms in spring and early summer.

AZALEAS AND RHODODENDRONS ARE PART OF THE RHODODENDRON FAMILY but, confusingly, while all azaleas are rhododendrons, not all rhododendrons are azaleas. Azaleas can be deciduous or evergreen, while rhododendrons are strictly evergreen and they also have slightly different flowers. However, both groups produce abundant, often scented, blooms in spring and early summer, and make excellent specimens for beds, borders, and containers. The larger rhododendrons are also useful as a hedge. Some species can be finicky growers, so choose those in this book or ask a specialist nursery for advice on the best plants for your garden. All require acidic soil, so test your soil before planting, and if you have alkaline conditions, grow compact or dwarf forms in pots of acidic planting mix. Happiest in moist soil and dappled or partial shade, trim plants lightly to keep them in shape in early summer, after flowering.

USING AZALEAS AND RHODODENDRONS

Large, shrubby rhododendrons make beautiful flowering evergreen screens. Trim them to shape in midsummer after flowering. Compact or dwarf rhododendrons are perfect for large containers or barrels, but they must be planted in acid soil or acidic planting mix. Water container-grown plants regularly, especially during summer.



The compact *R. yakushimanum* hybrids are invaluable for shady borders, producing masses of medium-sized flowers in late spring. There is a large range of colorful varieties to choose from.

Ideal for woodlands, azaleas and rhododendrons thrive in the cool dappled shade cast by neighboring trees. Plant them in groups for the best display.



TYPES OF AZALEA AND RHODODENDRON



Compact rhododendrons Forming mounds less than 3ft (1m) tall, this useful group consists of *R. yakushimanum* and *R. williamsianum* hybrids, which flower in late spring.



Shrub rhododendrons Most rhododendrons are rounded shrubs reaching hip- to head-height. Their colorful, often fragrant, flowers appear from mid-spring to early summer.